

The Holy Shadow

There is a story about a (Sufi) woman who is so good that the angles ask God to give her the gift of miracles. God wisely tells them to ask her if that is what she would wish.

So the angels visit this good woman and offer her first the gift of healing by hands, then the gift of conversion of souls, and lastly the gift of virtue. She refuses them all. They insist that she choose a gift or they will choose one for her. "Very well," she replies. "I ask that I may do a great deal of good without ever knowing it."

The angels were perplexed. They took counsel and resolved upon the following plan: Every time the saint's shadow fell behind her it would have the power to cure disease, soothe pain, and comfort sorrow. As she walked, behind her the shadow made arid paths green, caused withered plants to bloom, gave clear water to dried-up brooks, fresh color to pale children, and joy to unhappy men and women. The saint simply went about her daily life diffusing virtue as the stars diffuse light and the flowers scent, without ever being aware of it. The people respecting her humility followed her silently, never speaking to her about her miracles. Soon they even forgot her name and simply called her "the Holy Shadow."

Holy Shadow

Do you know any Holy Shadows - the sort of person who goes about doing good without even knowing it? I have come to learn that I actually do know a number of these Holy Shadows. They tend to fall into two types. The first type of Holy Shadow are the people who are doing their best to live a good life, trying where they can to be kind and helpful to others. These folks would like to be a blessing, but

don't feel that they have all that much to offer. But still, these people do try.

And truth be known, these individual were to discover that they were, in fact, a Holy Shadow, they would be very pleased.

Then there are the other Holy Shadows. These are the folks who are just doing the best they can. They may only be focused right now on surviving. They might be doing all they are able just to make it through the day. It is not as though they are purposely out to hurt others or to be selfish. They just simply do not have the skills, the energy, or sometimes the mental capacity to try to help others. If anyone were ever to tell them that they are a Holy Shadow, bestowing silent blessings upon others, their reaction would be profound disbelief. They would not even think it possible. Indeed, these are the Holy Shadows of the truest type.

A while ago, I sat having lunch with a fellow chaplain at a Senior Living Site. Her facility was similar to ones where I served as a full time chaplain in that there were a variety of differing levels of care and independence. My colleague told me that after 13 years of serving as a chaplain, she was leaving her position. We began to talk about what that meant for her and what her future might hold. And we talked about her leaving. I asked my friend what the hardest part about leaving was for her. Without a second's hesitation, she said, "The residents."

I began to inquire just what it was about these older folks that she would miss the most. And as my friend told me of her love for these people, she also reminded me of what I have known but not always spoken. Many of the elderly are Holy Shadows.

When people learn that I am a chaplain and work with the ill, the elderly, and the dying, they often ask me "How can you do that work? Don't you find it depressing?" They may even go on to add "If I get so old or so sick that I need care and assistance - just shoot me! I don't

ever want to end up in a nursing home!” Such a misunderstanding and a closed perception. I loved working in long term care. Let me tell you why.

There is a wide range of abilities and personalities among the elderly. Some easily fit the sweet and nurturing grandmother image. There are those who are elegant and gracious and delightfully proper. We have some crotchety old men and some mean old women. There are loving souls, forgetful characters, and worry warts. Some of the people are sharp and independent adults. Others are in need of total assistance and can no longer focus their eyes or chew their food. Most are somewhere in between.

And many, many of these people are Holy Shadows. Some of their blessings I have received first hand. Lovingly and unconsciously given. Some of this goodness has been experienced by other staff, volunteers, and guests. I interviewed a number of people in my quest to find out just why so many people who work with the elderly say they love it.

One of the most powerful gifts from the aged is just their presence. Just the fact that they are living and hanging in there. It may be that they have gathered some wisdom and insight through their years. Or it may simply be that they have not really learned a thing of value to pass on to younger generations. But there is the fact that they are here.

As the staff go about their lives, they face the various trials and struggles that come upon us all. Basic difficulties that most everyone encounters, as well as the horrible, unbelievable, and impossible hardships. My old folks lived through these things too. They have lived through the common troubles as well as the catastrophes we tend to think of as unique. No matter what the staff experienced, there are residents who have been through it too. - And they have lived.

It is a comfort being around someone who has made it through the hard stuff. It doesn't even matter if they came through battered and scarred. Just that they have been there, done that, and lived on, gives courage and stability. There is a solidness to being with people who have lived.

No matter what stories I hear from people, I have heard the same stories from my residents. A fight with a spouse or partner, they've been there. Trouble with the kids, been there. Severe financial difficulties? Problems with work? Loneliness, depression, fear? Medical problems? Mental health issues? Loss of a parent, partner, child, sibling, friend? They have been there.

With out getting specific, I will tell you that stories I have heard from younger people, which I had thought could happen only once in a million years - are also stories I have heard from the aged. Often times even worse. And they made it.

When my step-brother committed suicide, I gained strength from sitting and visiting with residents who have had similar experiences. We did not even have to talk about it. It was just steady and solid to sit with someone who had been through it too and lived.

The very presence of these old people is reassuring. It reminds us of the continuity of humanity. We see first hand the resilience of the human spirit. There is a tenacity about us mortals that is inspiring. Time does indeed heal a great many wounds. Life does go on. This is the gift of their presence alone.

There is another aspect to this business of the Holy Shadows among the ill and aged. This is the element of modeling. Watching and listening to elders raises the questions for me, "How do I want to live? Who do I want to be?"

Granted, anytime we are around others these questions can come up. We interact with people, see their sweetness, maturity, or impatience,

and have the opportunity to examine ourselves and our modes of living. But there is something about watching the aged that makes this questioning more poignant.

Those who are kind and gracious now were generally kind in their younger years. And by the same token, those who are angry, bitter, and ornery have only grown more so since their earlier days. Perhaps you have heard the phrase "Begin as you would go." However it is that we live our lives, this is often how we will be when we are older - only more so!

Have you ever spent time with an old woman who can not be pleased? Nothing is good enough for her. She doesn't seem to be happy unless she is complaining. Goodness help me, I don't ever want to grow into that!

Or what about the whiner? Until I worked as a chaplain in a nursing home, I honestly did not know that a person really could whine incessantly. I thought it was merely a figure of speech! Some people only know how to get attention by whining. I don't think they know just how forcefully they push others away. And as I am in the presence of these whiners, I think to myself - "How much whining did they do at my age? How can I prevent becoming a perpetual whiner?"

But then there are also the loving, the cheerful, the gracious, the kind, and the lively. A lifetime of practice has made these people a joy to know. Spending time with them, seeing them in the common rooms, giving them a ride in their wheelchair to diner, or holding their hand has become a blessing.

These are the people that are inspiring. Sure, I know a number of delightful adults. I work with people I admire and like. I have friends, colleagues, and acquaintances who possess qualities I regard highly. But it is truly another experience altogether to meet an older adult who personifies these traits. It is wonderful.

I remember one woman, Tilly was her name. She was a good soul. During the week that Tilly was dying, she was still responsive and alert. Her decline had taken some of her mental abilities and she no longer seemed to recognize individuals. But she could still talk and she appreciated company and the presence of others as she prepared to leave.

One morning I went in to sit with her. Tilly was resting quietly and might have been asleep. I pulled a chair up next to her bed, sat down, and took her hand. She opened her eyes, looked at me, and said "Oh, it's you. I love you."

How does a person get to be that loving? Tilly really didn't know who I was. She and I had spent some time together in the past, but I am sure that I was not the most precious person in her life. And yet, as she was preparing to die, her words were "Oh, it's you. I love you."

That is how I want to live. This is who I want to be. Tilly was love personified. And so I ask myself, "What must I do to become the kind of person that at the end of my days, I will be so good?"

Again, the Holy Shadow of the aged. It soothes and heals and blesses us.

The story of Tilly reminds me of one last gift from my old people. They teach us how to die.

Our culture is obsessed with youth and health and vigor. The media hardly shows pictures of the aged, infirm, and disabled. In many ways, our society would have us think they do not exist. Even when character are depicted as old or sick in the media, they often look like they could just get up and walk out of that wheelchair, or sit up and take off the little oxygen tube at their nose and stride out of the hospital.

Think about the times you ever seen a death on TV or in the movies? If it isn't violent or gory, it usually lasts about three minutes. It's quick. There may be a few carefully chosen and struggling spoken last words. And then it is over.

That's not how most people die. And by having the privilege of sitting with them and attending to them and waiting with them, I have been given a gift of inestimable value.

I don't know how many times I have read little poems and "inspirational" messages about what is important in life. I usually find them sweet and trite. But to sit with the dying, you really start to get a sense of what really is important. It cannot be condensed into an abstract and cute little poem. It is the core and the holiest part of life.

Families and friends come. And despite their fear or discomfort, they sit and they stay. And I think, what love is here. Somehow, this woman, or this man, has so raised his family and befriended her friends, that even at this most difficult time, they are here. Their love has compelled them. I want to live so well that I too can die well.

And my old folks teach me that dying is not so bad. It is nothing like the movies. It isn't necessarily painful. But in many ways, it is like birth and labor. It is natural, it is innate, and it comes in its own time. It is work coming into this world and it is work going out. We learn to wait with the dying and find in that time peace and serenity, even in the midst of grief.

There is the Holy Shadow which illuminates even the darkness of death.

There are gifts from the aged. To simply say that they have the wisdom of years is to miss the bigger picture. To limit our receptiveness to only those who are physically and mentally healthy is

too small. To think we can only be blessed by those who have their full minds or who still have command of their bodies is too narrow.

We hear the story of the Holy Shadow and we recall that every time the saint's shadow fell behind her it would have the power to cure disease, soothe pain, and comfort sorrow. As she walked, behind her the shadow made arid paths green, caused withered plants to bloom, gave clear water to dried-up brooks, fresh color to pale children, and joy to unhappy men and women. The saint simply went about her daily life diffusing virtue as the stars diffuse light and the flowers scent, without ever being aware of it. The people respecting her humility followed her silently, never speaking to her about her miracles. Soon they even forgot her name and simply called her "the Holy Shadow."

Remember, shadows stretch and expand when they fall. And the shadows of the late evening are the longest. They reach the furthest. Open yourself up to the Holy Shadows. Often those we would most easily dismiss have the greatest gifts to offer us.

Amen and Amen.

Look at your hand.

Look at your hand.

Whose hand is this
that has never died?

Who is it who was born in the past?

Who is it who will die in the future?

If you look deeply into the palm of your hand,
you will see your parents and all generations of your ancestors.
All of them are alive in this moment...

Previous generations, all the way back to single celled beings,
are present in your hand at this moment.

Thich Nhat Hanh

Tuesdays With Morrie

Morrie continued, "And, in addition to all the miseries, the young are not wise. They have very little understanding about life. Who wants to live every day when you don't know what's going on? When people are manipulating you, telling you to buy this perfume and you'll be beautiful, or this pair of jeans and you'll be sexy - and you believe them! It's such nonsense."

Weren't you ever afraid to grow old, I asked?

"Mitch, I embrace aging."

Embrace it?

"It's very simple. As you grow, you learn more. If you stayed at twenty-two, you'd always be as ignorant as you were at twenty-two. Aging is not just decay, you know. It's growth. It's more than the negative that you're going to die, it's also the positive that you understand that you're going to die, and that you live a better life because of it."

Yes, I said, but if aging were so valuable, why do people always say, "Oh, if I were young again." You never hear people say, "I wish I were sixty-five."

He smiled. "You know what that reflects? Unsatisfied lives. Unfulfilled lives. Lives that haven't found meaning. Because if you've found meaning in your life, you don't want to go back. You want to move forward. You want to see more, do more. You can't wait until sixty-five."

"Listen. You should know something. All younger people should know something. If you're always battling against getting older, you're always going to be unhappy, because it will happen anyhow."

Okay, I said, I'm wondering how you don't envy younger, healthier people. "Oh, I guess I do." He closed his eyes. "I envy them being able to go to the health club, or go for a swim. Or dance. Mostly for dancing. But envy comes to me, I feel it, and then I let it go. Remember what I said about detachment? Let it go. Tell yourself, 'That's envy, I'm going to separate from it now.' And walk away."

He coughed - a long, scratchy cough - and he pushed a tissue to his mouth and spit weakly into it. Sitting there, I felt so much stronger than he. Ridiculously so, as if I could lift him and toss him over my shoulder like a sack of flour. I was embarrassed by this superiority, because I did not feel superior to him in any other way.

How do you keep from envying...

"What?"

Me?

He smiled.

"Mitch, it is impossible for the old not to envy the young. But the issue is to accept who you are and revel in that. This is your time to be in your thirties. I had my time to be in my thirties, and now is my time to be seventy-eight.

"You have to find what's good and true and beautiful in your life as it is now. Looking back makes you competitive. And age is not a competitive issue." He exhaled and lowered his eyes, as if to watch his breath scatter into the air.

"The truth is, part of me is every age. I'm a three-year-old, I'm a five-year-old, I'm a thirty-seven-year-old, I'm a fifty-year-old. I've been through all of them, and I know what it's like. I delight in being a child when it's appropriate to be a child. I delight in being a wise old man when

it's appropriate to be a wise old man. Think of all I can be! I am every age, up to my own. Do you understand?"

I nodded.

"How can I be envious of where you are - when I've been there myself?"

Readings

Senility Prayer:

God, grant me the senility
to forget the people I never liked anyway,
the good fortune to run into the ones I do,
and the eyesight to tell the difference.

Order of Service

Spirit of Life Unitarian Universalist Church
St. Cloud
January 13, 2013
10:30 am

Welcome & Announcements

Opening Words

Chalice Lighting (In Unison)

At times our own light goes out
and is rekindled by a spark from another person.
Each of us has cause to think of those
who have lighted the flame within us.

Opening Hymn #191 Now I Recall My Childhood

Sharing Joys & Concerns

Children's Story

Responsive Reading # 669

Offering

Readings

Thich Nhat Hanh

Tuesdays With Morrie

Silent Meditation

Sermon "The Holy Shadow" - Rev. Shelley Dugan

Dialog

Hymn #306 Sing Of Living, Sing Of Dying

Reading

Senility Prayer

Closing Hymn # 16 'Tis a Gift to be Simple

Extinguishing The Chalice (In Unison)

We extinguish this flame but not the light of truth,
the warmth of community,
the fire of commitment.

These we carry in our hearts

Until we are together again.

Benediction